

100 Days of Linux - Day 015

Title: Reading Large Files with less

Today's Goal

Learn how to read large text files one screen at a time using the **less** command.

Why This Matters

Large log files, CSV files, and configuration files are common in software development and data engineering. The **less** command lets you browse them efficiently without printing the entire file to the terminal.

Command of the Day: less

Syntax: less filename

Explanation: Opens a file in an interactive viewer where you can scroll up and down.

Useful Keys:

Space = Next page

b = Previous page

Arrow Keys = Scroll line by line

/text = Search for text

q = Quit

Example: less server.log

Beginner Lesson

Unlike **cat**, which prints the whole file at once, **less** lets you move through a file page by page. This makes it much easier to inspect large files.

Practice Questions

1. Create a file named notes.txt with at least 25 lines and open it using less.
2. Inside less, move to the next page and then return to the previous page.
3. Search for a word that appears in your file using the search feature.
4. Exit less using the correct keyboard key.
5. Display your current working directory after finishing the exercise.

Hints

Remember that less is interactive. Try pressing Space, b, Arrow keys, / to search, and q to quit.

Mini Challenge

Create a file named employees.txt with 30 lines. Open it with less, search for one employee name, scroll to the bottom, then quit.

Common Mistakes

Typing navigation keys as commands. Keys like Space and q are pressed while inside less, not at the shell prompt.

Did You Know?

The less command is one of the most frequently used tools for viewing Linux log files.

Pro Tip

If you're reading a large log file, use less instead of cat to avoid flooding your terminal.

Answer Key (Instructor Only)

Q1: less notes.txt

Q2: Press Space, then b

Q3: Press / followed by the search text and Enter

Q4: Press q

Q5: pwd

Homework

Create two large text files and practice scrolling, searching, and quitting with less until you can do it without looking at your notes.

Next Day Preview

Tomorrow you'll learn the more command and compare it with less to understand when each tool is useful.